Hollywood thrillers and spy novels. Outsiders simply don't understand what intelligence agencies actually do. Nor do they understand the necessarily secretive and often cynical deal-making at the heart of diplomacy. That ignorance may be healthy. But when it is breached, people are shocked.

Responsible journalism has trouble dealing with secret and hence uncheckable information released by sources with a political agenda. Most of Snowden's leaked documents consist of slides, presumably used in internal presentations. But what do they represent? Are the operations and capabilities described merely planned, long since abandoned, or actually under way? How widespread are they? Who are the targets? What do the preceding and following slides say? Who is the audience for this presentation? What objections or questions were posed? This context is crucial. Journalists usually scrutinise leaked documents for exactly these links and clues. Yet in the case of the Snowden revelations, there has been no such scrutiny.

A third element fuelling support for Snowden is genuine concern about the way in which computer processing-power and digital storage affect the privacy and anonymity that we have long taken for granted. The term 'mass surveillance' may be misleading, but it resonates. Official responses to the Snowden revelations have been lame. The White House blames the NSA for allowing the documents to leak; its rebuttals to the claims made have been laconic and dutiful, rather than vigorous. Allies fume, mostly silently.

The security and intelligence agencies in democratic countries are not used to dealing with non-specialist media. They prize (rightly) secrecy over setting the record straight. Explaining why a leaked secret document does not mean what it purports to mean may result in giving away another secret, perhaps still more valuable to an adversary. Moreover, the climate created by the leaks, and memories of past deception,